

Sustainable
Community-based
—— Urban Architecture

“Architecture is
not about creating a space,
but about creating relationships.”



- Riken Yamamoto



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Architecture connecting diversity
building by building. 664



Meet Riken Yamamoto.

He was born in 1945 in Beijing, China. During his childhood he relocated to Yokohama, Japan after the end of World War II. Here, his home was a combination of a public and private space, inspired by the traditional Japanese building *machiya*. His mother's pharmacy was located at the front of their home, while their living area was tucked behind it. Growing up in such a dynamic meant that **he sat in between two dimensions: public and private life.**

When Yamamoto was 17, he visited Kôfuku-ji Temple in Nara, Japan where he would become enthralled with its five-story pagoda that symbolized each Buddhist element. He recalls that as he stood there, he was mesmerized by how the moon lit up the dark tower. This was his first experience with architecture, which led him to journey on his path of becoming an architect. Specifically, one that **revolutionized community-based urban landscape.**

Yamamoto graduated from Nihon University in 1968 and obtained his Masters of Arts in Architecture from Tokyo University of the Arts in 1971. In his early years as an architect, Yamamoto traveled across various countries and continents by car with Hiroshi Hara, his mentor. Such was done with the purpose of gaining an understanding of communities, cultures, and civilizations. He traveled through the coastline of the Mediterranean Sea in 1972, the Americas in 1974, the Middle East, and South Asia concluding a certain threshold lies between public and private spaces. In **1973**, Yamamoto **founded** his architectural firm known as **Riken Yamamoto & Field Shop.**



1977



Yamakawa Villa

the first client project



Philosophy

Yamamoto's work expresses sustainable urban design that strengthens collective identity while respecting privacy. He creates architecture that dissolves barriers yet supports individual space, enabling diverse cultures and histories to coexist. Adaptability is central to his approach. Flexible layouts, such as the reconfigurable walls in the Future University Hakodate Research Building (2005), allow spaces to shift with changing needs.

Sustainability is equally integral as Yamamoto tailors each project to its environment, reducing environmental impact through harmonious siting, reliance on natural light, water-recycling systems, and local or recycled materials. An example of such is The Circle at Zurich Airport. His frequent use of open terraces and balconies highlights the dialogue between buildings and their occupants, reinforcing a sense of connection over isolation.

"I think of architecture as a social situation within an environment."
-Riken Yamamoto

Timeline

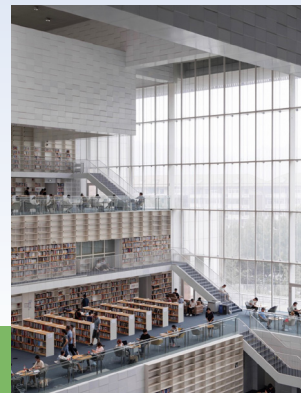


1986

Designed GAZEBO

Yokohama, Japan

Yamamoto's home. A structure that combines the function of a living area, office, and shop while cultivating interaction with the local community.



2010

Pangyo Housing

Seongnam, Korea

A collaborative project with Pekka Helin and Mark Mack, winners of a competition held by Korea, to design environmental-friendly homes.

2012

Tianjin Library

Tianjin, China

A five layer library with mezzanine levels encasing more than 5 million books. Designed to be sustainable, while offering diverse reading spaces.

2016

Yokohama City University Buildings

Yokohama, Japan

Rather than trying to achieve a symbolic value in the architectural design, the project proposed that the interaction of students and faculty should become the symbol.



2020

The Circle

Zurich Airport, Switzerland

A spacious building that had to express the beauty of contemporary Switzerland while also satisfying the needs of the diverse backgrounds that travel through.



● ● Shinonome Canal Court CODAN



2024

**Received The Pritzker
Architecture Award**

The highest honor in architecture awarded for Yamamoto's dedication to uniting the diversity of societies through harmonious structures.

2025

**Received Crystal Prize
World Economic Forum**

Awarded for Yamamoto's extensive contributions to community regeneration and sustainable design architecture across various countries.

Taoyuan Museum of Art is divided into **two buildings:**
the art museum building (2026) & the children's museum (2024).

Both were designed in consideration of the relationship with the surrounding environment. The surrounding ground is raised to form a hill-like slope with ramps and pergolas to host park-like activities. With a 30-degree incline, the hill has several holes that form terraces from where people can enter as if crawling under the roof. Tucked between the roof and the interior exhibition rooms are rich spaces by terraced various activities such as cafe and library. The museum can be enjoyed while always feeling the relationship with the outside.



Instead, during a career spanning the last five decades, he has produced a consistent body of work in a neutral, modernist style, creating cubic, gridded forms in steel, concrete and glass, which might be hard to get excited about at first glance. But a closer look reveals further complexity and sophistication in how his buildings are layered and structured with social interaction foremost in mind, always designed to foster a sense of community, collective life and mutual aid. As the Pritzker prize jury put it, Yamamoto's architecture serves "both as background and foreground to everyday life, blurring boundaries between its public and private dimensions, and multiplying opportunities for people to meet spontaneously.

Riken Yamamoto has really spent his entire life creating architecture that, I would say, connects the dignity of architecture with human social conditions in a very generous, quiet way. He does public buildings that feel as though they belong in the communities in which they sit. They enrich the lives of those communities. It's not just fancy buildings. Although he does beautiful, "fancy" buildings like museums, he also does housing and fire stations and city halls. So, buildings that serve their communities. They're not necessarily monumental. They're really about bringing dignity to everyday life and elegance to everyday life.

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